

Country Background

Sudan is located in northeastern Africa and borders Egypt, Libya, Chad, the Central African Republic, South Sudan, Ethiopia, and Eritrea. The country also has a coastline along the Red Sea.

Sudan is ethnically, culturally, and linguistically diverse. Its population includes Arab and African communities, Nubian communities, Beja communities, Fur, Masalit, Zaghawa, Nuba, and many other ethnic groups. Arabic and English are widely used, alongside numerous local languages.

Sudan's capital is Khartoum, where the Blue Nile and White Nile meet. Other important cities include Omdurman, Khartoum North, Port Sudan, El Obeid, Wad Madani, Nyala, El Fasher, Geneina, and Kassala.

Sudan has important agricultural land, livestock, gold, oil, and Red Sea trade routes. However, poverty, political instability, conflict, displacement, weak public services, economic crisis, and climate-related disasters have affected the country for many years.

Independence and Early Political History

Sudan became independent from Anglo-Egyptian rule on 1 January 1956. Since independence, Sudan has experienced repeated military coups, civil wars, political instability, and disputes over the distribution of power and resources.

The first Sudanese civil war lasted from 1955 to 1972 and was fought mainly between the central government and southern armed groups. The conflict ended with the Addis Ababa Agreement, which granted limited autonomy to southern Sudan.

The second Sudanese civil war began in 1983 after the government introduced policies that weakened southern autonomy and imposed broader Islamic laws. The war ended with the Comprehensive Peace Agreement in 2005. South Sudan became independent in 2011.

Darfur Conflict

The Darfur conflict began in 2003 when armed movements opposed the Sudanese government, accusing it of political marginalization, unequal development, and discrimination against communities in western Sudan.

The government responded through military operations and support for Arab militias commonly referred to as Janjaweed. Large-scale attacks caused killings, rape, destruction of villages, livestock losses, and mass displacement.

The Darfur conflict produced one of the largest humanitarian crises of the early twenty-first century. Millions of people were forced to flee to displacement camps or

neighbouring Chad. Although several peace agreements were signed, insecurity and communal violence continued.

Darfur remains heavily affected by armed conflict, ethnic tensions, land disputes, food insecurity, and displacement.

Omar al-Bashir Government

Omar Hassan al-Bashir seized power in a military coup in 1989. His government remained in power for approximately thirty years.

The government was accused of suppressing political opposition, restricting freedom of expression, detaining critics, using security forces against civilians, and committing serious abuses during conflicts in Darfur, South Kordofan, and Blue Nile.

In 2009, the International Criminal Court issued an arrest warrant for Omar al-Bashir on charges including war crimes, crimes against humanity, and genocide relating to the Darfur conflict. The charges remain part of the international legal history of the conflict.

Sudanese Revolution and the 2019 Transition

Large public protests began in December 2018 after rising prices, shortages, and economic hardship. The protests developed into a nationwide movement demanding the removal of President Omar al-Bashir and the establishment of civilian democratic government.

Omar al-Bashir was removed from power on 11 April 2019 by the Sudanese military. A Transitional Military Council initially assumed power.

Following negotiations between military leaders and civilian representatives, the Constitutional Charter for the Transitional Period was signed in August 2019. The charter established a transitional power-sharing arrangement between civilian and military representatives and included a Bill of Rights.

The transition was weakened by political disagreements, economic problems, security-sector divisions, and continuing military influence.

The 2021 Military Coup

On 25 October 2021, General Abdel Fattah al-Burhan and military leaders dissolved the transitional civilian government and declared a state of emergency.

The coup ended the planned transition toward civilian democratic rule. Protests continued, and security forces were accused of killing and injuring demonstrators, conducting arbitrary arrests, and restricting freedom of expression and assembly.

The coup also increased tensions between the Sudanese Armed Forces and the Rapid Support Forces.

Main Parties to the Current War

The current war is mainly fought between the **Sudanese Armed Forces**, known as the SAF, and the **Rapid Support Forces**, known as the RSF.

The SAF is Sudan's regular military and is led by General Abdel Fattah al-Burhan. It includes the army, air force, and other military formations.

The RSF is a powerful paramilitary force led by General Mohamed Hamdan Dagalo, commonly known as Hemedti. The RSF developed from the Janjaweed militias that operated during the Darfur conflict and was formally established by Sudanese law in 2013.

Both sides have been accused by United Nations investigators and human rights organizations of serious violations, including attacks against civilians, unlawful killings, sexual violence, forced displacement, looting, arbitrary detention, torture, and destruction of civilian property.

Beginning of the War in April 2023

Open fighting began on 15 April 2023 after escalating tensions between the SAF and RSF.

A central dispute concerned the future of Sudan's security sector. The parties disagreed about how and when the RSF would be integrated into the regular army, who would control the armed forces, and how Sudan would return to civilian government.

Fighting began in Khartoum and quickly spread to other parts of the country. Airports, military bases, bridges, hospitals, markets, residential areas, government buildings, and communication systems were affected.

The fighting divided the capital and forced millions of people to flee their homes. Many civilians were trapped without food, water, electricity, healthcare, or safe routes out of the conflict zones.

Expansion of the War

The conflict spread to Darfur, Kordofan, Gezira, Blue Nile, Khartoum, and other areas.

The RSF gained control over large parts of Khartoum and several areas of Darfur. The SAF maintained control over Port Sudan, parts of northern and eastern Sudan, and important military facilities. Control of towns and roads has changed repeatedly as both sides launch offensives.

Darfur has experienced some of the most serious ethnic and civilian protection concerns. El Fasher, the capital of North Darfur, became a major centre of fighting and humanitarian crisis. Civilian populations in Darfur have faced attacks, siege conditions, displacement, and restricted humanitarian access.

Humanitarian Impact

The war has created one of the world's largest displacement crises. According to the 2026 Sudan Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan, approximately 9.3 million people were internally displaced as of 30 October 2025. Sudan also hosted more than 860,000 refugees during the reporting period.

Millions of other people crossed into Chad, Egypt, South Sudan, Ethiopia, Libya, and the Central African Republic. Many refugees and returnees live in overcrowded areas with limited food, shelter, healthcare, clean water, sanitation, and protection.

The conflict has destroyed homes, markets, schools, hospitals, water systems, roads, farms, warehouses, and government offices. Banking services and communication systems have also been interrupted in many areas.

Food Insecurity and Famine Risk

Conflict has prevented farmers from planting and harvesting crops, disrupted markets, destroyed livestock, restricted trade routes, and increased food prices.

Displaced families often lose their land, homes, livestock, tools, income, and documents. Children, pregnant women, breastfeeding mothers, older people, and people with disabilities face increased risks of hunger and malnutrition.

Humanitarian organizations have warned of famine and famine-like conditions in parts of Sudan. Food assistance has been difficult to deliver because of insecurity, blocked roads, bureaucratic restrictions, fighting, checkpoints, and attacks on humanitarian convoys.

Healthcare Crisis

Many hospitals and clinics have been damaged, looted, occupied, or forced to close. Health workers have been killed, injured, displaced, or unable to reach their workplaces.

The collapse of health services has increased the risks of maternal deaths, child deaths, infectious diseases, malnutrition, cholera, measles, malaria, and untreated conflict-related injuries.

People with chronic illnesses, including diabetes, hypertension, kidney disease, and HIV, may be unable to access medication and regular treatment.

Gender-Based Violence

Women and girls face increased risks of rape, sexual slavery, forced marriage, sexual exploitation, trafficking, domestic violence, and abuse at checkpoints or during displacement.

Survivors may be unable to access medical treatment, emergency contraception, psychosocial support, legal assistance, or safe shelters because health facilities have been destroyed or services have been suspended.

Children and Education

The conflict has created one of the world's largest child-displacement emergencies. Millions of children have been forced from their homes and many are no longer attending school.

Children face recruitment, abduction, family separation, sexual violence, forced marriage, trafficking, disease, hunger, and psychological trauma.

Schools have been destroyed, occupied by armed forces, converted into shelters, or closed because teachers and students cannot travel safely.

Humanitarian Situation

Humanitarian access remains difficult in several parts of Sudan. Humanitarian workers face insecurity, looting, roadblocks, administrative restrictions, attacks, detention, and communication interruptions.

The United Nations and humanitarian organizations continue to call for:

- Protection of civilians.
- Safe and sustained humanitarian access.
- Respect for international humanitarian law.
- An end to attacks on hospitals, schools, markets, and humanitarian facilities.
- A negotiated ceasefire.
- Accountability for serious crimes.
- A return to civilian-led governance